Plan a circle: “To Build a Fire”

Jack London (1908) · public-domain short story · grades 8–11 · ~1 week / two meetings. Rights: Public domain.

Kit section 5 (group agreement & calendar) filled in for one text — a finished plan students see before writing their own. ***Tinted italic*** = sample answers.

Text, group, and target

Text / author / edition	***“To Build a Fire” — Jack London (1908). Public-domain short story.***
Group / period / dates	***Noah’s group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___***
Grade / TEKS target (p. 3)	English I · §110.36 — 6(A): theme through characterization/plot; 5(C,D): commentary and summary; 1(D): student-led discussion.
Learning intention	We are learning to explain how the man’s choices and the setting reveal a theme about nature and human pride.
Success criteria	I bring one open question, cite two details with locations, respond to a peer, and name how my thinking changed.

Reading map & calendar

Chunk	Read through	Meeting date · leader
1	***The man sets out at 75-below despite the old-timer’s warning, and breaks through the ice.***	***Tue · Leader: Noah***
2	***The failed fires, the growing panic, and the ending — the dog moves on.***	***Thu · Leader: Elena***

Members & first-meeting jobs (p. 7 roles)

Member	First job	Rotates to (next meeting)
Noah	***Questioner***	***Summarizer***
Elena	***Summarizer***	***Clarifier***
Ravi	***Clarifier***	***Evidence tracker***
Grace	***Predictor***	***Questioner***

Text-specific discussion questions (open — more than one answer)

- **Predict:** After the man ignores the old-timer’s advice, what will the cold force him to face? What clue supports it?
- **Question:** Why might London give the dog instincts the man lacks? What does that contrast argue?
- **Clarify:** What does “the trouble with him was that he was without imagination” mean for his fate?
- **Summarize:** Order the man’s attempts to survive after he gets wet, without opinion.
- **Interpret the theme:** How do the man’s choices and the setting reveal a theme about nature vs. pride? Use two details.

Optional Jigsaw lenses (p. 4): ***Character*** (the man and the dog) · ***Setting*** (the Yukon cold as antagonist) · ***Plot*** (the chain of small errors) · ***Theme*** (instinct vs. arrogance) · ***Language*** (repetition of temperature and warnings).

Sample 3–2–1 notes: Ravi, setting lens

Name: Ravi · *Home group: Noah's group* · *Period __* · *Meetings ___ & ___* · *Section: "To Build a Fire," Chunk 2* · *Expert lens: Setting*

What a finished prep looks like. Kit section 6 / Organizer A completed for one reader, so students can compare their notes to a strong model.

Questions

Could the man have survived with the dog's instincts?

Is the ending fate, or his own doing?

3 · Important ideas

1. The cold is an active force, not just a backdrop.
2. Small mistakes — getting wet, a badly placed fire — turn fatal.
3. The dog reads danger the man dismisses.

Vocabulary

conjectural = based on guessing.

apprehension = uneasy awareness of danger.

2 · Supporting details

1. The man's spittle crackles in the air (early). → *Shows how extreme and deadly the cold is.*
2. Snow from the spruce buries his fire (middle). → *Nature punishes his haste.*

1 · Summary in my own words

A man travels alone in deadly cold, ignores a warning, and dies after failing to keep a fire; the dog moves on.

Bring to the circle

My interpretation: *Nature is indifferent; survival needs humility and instinct, not confidence.*
Synthesis (two lenses): *The environment (setting) enacts the theme: pride without imagination cannot survive an indifferent nature. Text points: the crackling cold (Chunk 1) and the buried fire (Chunk 2).*
After discussion: *My thinking became clearer once the group compared evidence.*

TEKS evidence: 6(C,D) supported inference; 7(A) theme through characters/events; 1(D) response to a peer. · Pair with the PlotPoint "To Build a Fire" room.